

The room is quieter than it used to be. The summer heat warning flashes across my phone display again, but inside, the clinic is cool, controlled, safe. I kneel in front of Mateo, who is six and determined not to look at me. “Your turn,” I say gently, holding up the picture card. A boy blowing bubbles. “What’s he doing?” Mateo shrugs, eyes still fixed on the floor. His mother watches from the corner, hands clasped tight, like she’s holding something fragile that might break if she breathes wrong. Twenty years ago, this moment might’ve been simple. A speech delay, a few months of therapy, progress charts, gold star stickers. I read his file again in my head: displacement at age three due to coastal flooding, multiple relocations, disrupted schooling, prolonged periods of poor air quality exposure. Words like “regression” and “trauma-induced mutism” sit heavy behind my smile. I lower the card. “We can just sit,” I tell him, because sometimes that’s the work now.

When I was in college, I thought being a speech-language pathologist meant helping kids pronounce their R’s or supporting stroke patients relearn language. Somewhere along the way, the job shifted, or maybe the world did.

I glance at Mateo’s mom again. “How was the air quality this week?” I ask. “Better,” she says, though her voice hesitates. “We stayed inside most days.” I nod, “That helps.” Mateo finally looks up at me, just for a second. I catch it, “You saw something outside this week?” I ask, softer now. He hesitates, then, very quietly says “Bird.” His mom exhales sharply, like she’s been holding that breath for days. I smile, steady, even though something in my chest tightens. “A bird? That’s amazing. What kind?” He shrugs again, but this time it’s different, “Big one.” I nod, “Maybe a hawk.” He looks at me again, longer this time, then his eyes shoot back down to the floor.

After the session, I step into the hallway. My coworker Jasmine leans against the wall, scrolling through updates. “Another heat closure tomorrow,” she says without looking up. “Schools are shifting to remote again, how’d your session go?” “Small win,” I say. “He said ‘bird.’” Jasmine smiles big and says, “That’s huge.” And it is, words are harder to come by now. Not just for kids like Mateo, but for all of us. There are things we’re still learning how to say out loud.

Later that evening, I sit on my apartment balcony as the sun sets. The air quality app says it’s “moderate,” which means I can stay outside for a little while. I think about Mateo. I think about how one word can carry so much. I pull out my journal, the one I’ve kept since college. Back then, I used to write about who I thought I’d become. There’s a page where I scribbled: *I want to help people find their voices*. I smile at that. It sounds silly, naive, even. But maybe I wasn’t wrong. Somewhere out there, Mateo saw a bird this week. Not a filtered image of a bird on a screen, but a real, living thing moving through the air. And he found a way to say it. Tomorrow, we’ll build on that. Another word, maybe two. A sentence, eventually. Small things, but small things add up.